Britain, Soviet Russia, Afghanistan and Persia actually change the dynamic within South Asia? In practical terms, yes. The signing of a treaty between Moscow and Tehran, for instance, meant that from 1921 onwards, a Bolshevik envoy would now receive full recognition from the Persian government – no longer were Lenin and his comrades international pariahs. The Anglo-Soviet Trade Agreement may not have been a watershed in relations between those two countries, but it did mark a begrudging acceptance by the British government that it could not continue to ignore the Soviet government.

In Afghanistan too, things were to change to an extent. Despite the unreasonable demands of the Home government, Dobbs was finally able to negotiate an agreement with the emir in November 1921 – one that even resolved the thorny issue of Soviet consulates.[156] Now that Afghanistan was an independent country in all its external affairs, it also insisted that following this treaty all its future relations with Britain were to be conducted through the Foreign Office in London, just as any other sovereign nation, as opposed to through Delhi. This meant that, at least superficially, from 1921 the Foreign Office was now to have control over Britain's Afghan policy. While care was taken by Montagu to set up a system whereby the India Office still retained a final (albeit surreptitious) say over Afghan affairs, it was inevitable that after 1921 the Indian government would lose some of the little freedom of action it had had in Afghanistan.[157]

Psychologically, however, there were many British officials who struggled to cope with these developments. Curzon, for example, resented the position Britain was now in with Persia, but found himself powerless to do anything about it. Rather than admit his mistakes and adjust his policies accordingly, Curzon expressed his frustration with bitter remonstration against those he felt had personally affronted him – the Persian government. When it came to Afghanistan, Montagu could not come to terms with the idea that Britain was no longer able to control that country's foreign relations. By insisting on unattainable concessions from Kabul, the secretary of state made the Indian government's work during the peace negotiations that much harder.